

FREE CHECKLIST

The CTO Readiness Checklist

Twenty questions every founder should be able to answer about their technology. Tick the ones you can answer with confidence. The gaps are where a CTO earns their keep.

How to use this

Go through the twenty questions honestly. For each one, tick Yes if you could answer it today without asking anyone, *Partly* if you have a rough idea, and *No* if you would have to go and find out. Scoring is at the end.

☐ Yes ☐ Partly ☐ No

STRATEGY AND DIRECTION

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- 01 **Can you explain, in two sentences, what your technology needs to do in the next twelve months?** ☐ ☐ ☐

If the plan lives only in one developer's head, it is not a plan.

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- 02 **Do you know which parts of your product you should build and which you should buy?** ☐ ☐ ☐

Most early teams build things a vendor would sell them for the price of a lunch.

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- 03 **Do you know what your technology costs per month, per customer?** ☐ ☐ ☐

Cloud, licences, contractors, tools. If the number is a guess, so is your margin.

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- 04 **Could you tell an investor or buyer what technical debt you carry and what it would cost to clear?** ☐ ☐ ☐

Every diligence process asks. The good answer is a short list, not a shrug.

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- 05 **Is there a written record of the big technical decisions and why they were made?** ☐ ☐ ☐

Not documentation of everything. Just the choices that would be expensive to reverse.

PEOPLE AND DELIVERY

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- 06 **If your lead developer resigned tomorrow, could someone else ship a change within a week?** ☐ ☐ ☐

This is the single most common risk in a small technical team.

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- 07 **Do you know how long it takes from deciding on a change to customers using it?** ☐ ☐ ☐

Days is healthy. Months means something is broken in the process, not the people.

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- 08 **Are you confident you are paying your developers and agencies the right amount for what you get?** ☐ ☐ ☐

Not the cheapest. The right amount.

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- 09 **Do you know who you need to hire next, and could you tell a good candidate from a fluent one?** ☐ ☐ ☐

Technical interviews are where non-technical founders get burned most often.

- 10 **Does your team get a clear priority list, or do they get whichever request arrived last?** ☐ ☐ ☐
- Ask them. The answer is often not what the founder thinks.

PLATFORM AND RISK

- 11 **Do you own every account your business runs on: domain, cloud, source code, app stores, payments?** ☐ ☐ ☐
- If any of these are in a contractor's name, fix that this week.
- 12 **If your main system went down on a Monday morning, do you know who would be called and what they would do?** ☐ ☐ ☐
- An incident plan on one page beats none at all.
- 13 **Are backups taken, and has anyone ever actually restored from one?** ☐ ☐ ☐
- An untested backup is a hope, not a backup.
- 14 **Do you know where your customer data lives and who can access it?** ☐ ☐ ☐
- This is the question a privacy complaint or a large customer's security team will ask first.
- 15 **Does every person who has left the business still have access to anything?** ☐ ☐ ☐
- Check. It is almost always yes.

PRODUCT AND GROWTH

- 16 **Do you know which features customers actually use, from data rather than from feel?** ☐ ☐ ☐
- Half of most products goes untouched. Knowing which half changes what you build next.
- 17 **Could your systems handle ten times the customers without a rebuild?** ☐ ☐ ☐
- You do not need to be ready for it today. You need to know what would break first.
- 18 **Have you looked at where AI or automation would remove real work from your team's week?** ☐ ☐ ☐
- Not a chatbot on the website. The manual, repeated, error-prone work inside the business.
- 19 **Do you have a way to test an idea with customers before committing a build budget to it?** ☐ ☐ ☐
- A prototype, a mock-up, a landing page. Anything cheaper than the real thing.
- 20 **Do you have someone senior to talk to before you make a technical decision you cannot easily undo?** ☐ ☐ ☐
- If the answer is no, that is the gap this checklist exists to point at.

Scoring

16 to 20 Yes: You are in good shape. An Advisor engagement, a few hours a week, is usually all you need to stay that way.

10 to 15 Yes: Common for a growing business. The gaps are known and fixable. This is where a Fractional CTO, one or two days a week, pays for itself quickly.

Under 10 Yes: You are carrying more risk than you can see. Start with a technical audit so you know exactly what you are dealing with, then decide what kind of help you need.

Want a second opinion on your answers? Book a free thirty-minute discovery call. No pitch, just a clearer picture of where your technology stands. thefractionalcto.com.au